

/website build-off local food shops

Local food shops are dwindling, so we asked three designers to inject some new online life into independent retail

The brief

The homepage for a local food shop site should convey the quality of products as well as the shop's history, and include online ordering and feedback options. It's quite likely the business owner isn't very internet-savvy and hasn't got a big budget, so it needs to be user-friendly.

Designers



Name Naomi Atkinson
Company Naomi Atkinson Design
URL www.naomiatkinson.com
After many years at three top London agencies, working with clients including Audi, Macmillan Cancer Support and British Telecom, Naomi now runs her own small studio. And loves it.



Name Jack Osborne
Company Freelance
URL www.jackosborne.co.uk
Jack Osborne is a designer based on the west coast of Scotland. He has recently taken the leap of faith and joined the world of freelance. You can find him pontificating on Twitter (@jackosborne).



Name Rob Edwards
Company Sequence
URL www.sequence.co.uk
Rob Edwards is a creative designer at Sequence, a full-service digital marketing agency whose clients include the BBC, Storm Models, Eversheds, Rachel's Organic and Brains.

Naomi Atkinson's solution

Milkmen, like local food shops selling fresh produce, are dwindling in numbers and I would just hate to see this traditional service disappear. Milkmen work mainly on paper: they have a book in which they keep everything tallied up, while customers write notes and stick them in the top of returned bottles.

What if we were to create a service that made everything easier for both the milkman and the customer?

We'd need a back-end that could match customers to their local milkman via postcodes. The customer could then manage their orders and payments, and the milkman and dairy suppliers would know their numbers. Payment would be automatic, meaning one less job (and a lot less worry) for the milkman.

I for one would love such a service. I rely on my local corner shop for milk, meaning I'm tied to their opening hours. My schedule is always hectic and can take me away from home a lot. So I'd love nothing more than to be able to make sure I can have a cup of tea on my return from a few weeks away.

Other than supermarkets delivering goods, I've only seen one site offering anything similar: www.milkandmore.co.uk. The problem is that it's for a brand. We should instead be supporting milkmen who want to stay self-employed.

I'm thinking of the bigger picture here — this is all of our country's milkmen being taken care of, offering a great service to their customers, and ultimately staying around for many more decades to come. ●

Expert info



Naomi Atkinson's month

What have I been doing?

I've consulted for a few agencies, put the design direction together for a well-known college in London and a popular music store, as well as launching my own product site (naomiatickinsonproducts.com).

Sites I've visited

I haven't been able to pry myself away from Dribbble and FFFFOUND! I much prefer browsing and gathering inspiration in this meandering fashion rather than looking at anything too specific. It gets the juices flowing.

What have I been watching?

True Blood, *Sherlock* and plenty of property programmes — I'd love to do a renovation project of my own one day.

What have I been listening to?

Everything from Röyksopp, Radiohead and Portishead right through to Chopin. The right music can really help me be more productive.

Turn over to see solutions from Jack Osborne and Rob Edwards >>

Close up



1 The style A modern take on the 1950s. Style is extremely important here, as we're pulling on people's memories, whether it be their old milkman or their morning mini-bottle of milk during their school days.

4 Text rotation We can use CSS to rotate the text by using the transform property for WebKit and Firefox (as of 3.5), and the BasicImage filter for IE (check out snook.ca/archives/html_and_css/css-text-rotation).

2 The layout The grid is based on Less Framework 2 (www.lessframework.com). It uses inline CSS3 media queries to switch between an eight-, five- or two-column layout based on browser width.

5 Text shadows A nice effect many designers are making use of is the text-shadow property. Adding a 1px highlight or shadow to text can really help lift it off the page. Lovely for headings.

3 Fonts All the fonts used are free from www.fontsquirrel.com. They're all @font-face web fonts, meaning there's no need for any image replacement. Just remember to specify fallback fonts for older browsers.

6 App UI Keeping the design of an app clean and simple is a necessity. For the user, familiarity almost always equates to ease of use — the app's UI is very similar to iCal for good reason.

Expert info



Jack Osborne's month

What have I been doing?

I've been working on the new HTML5 Doctor website and a website for a major Scottish venue. I've also started to set the wheels in motion for a design conference I'm setting up called Weegies: weegi.es.

Sites I've visited

Sites that I have been visiting for inspiration are Dribbble (dribbble.com), FFFFOUND! (ffffound.com) and siteInspire (siteinspire.net). I always seem to keep going back to these websites. However, when possible I like to try and get my inspiration from offline sources.

What have I been watching?

Recently, I've been watching the reruns of *The Inbetweeners* in preparation for the new series. I've also been watching a lot of football since the new season started.

What have I been listening to?

I've been listening to Two Door Cinema Club, The Maccabees, The Strokes (I'm rediscovering them all over again) and the Same For You podcast. Funny.

Jack Osborne's solution

Mortons Family Bakers have been in the local community for decades. Their budget for the project isn't great so they're looking for simple solutions to help drive more sales through their website.

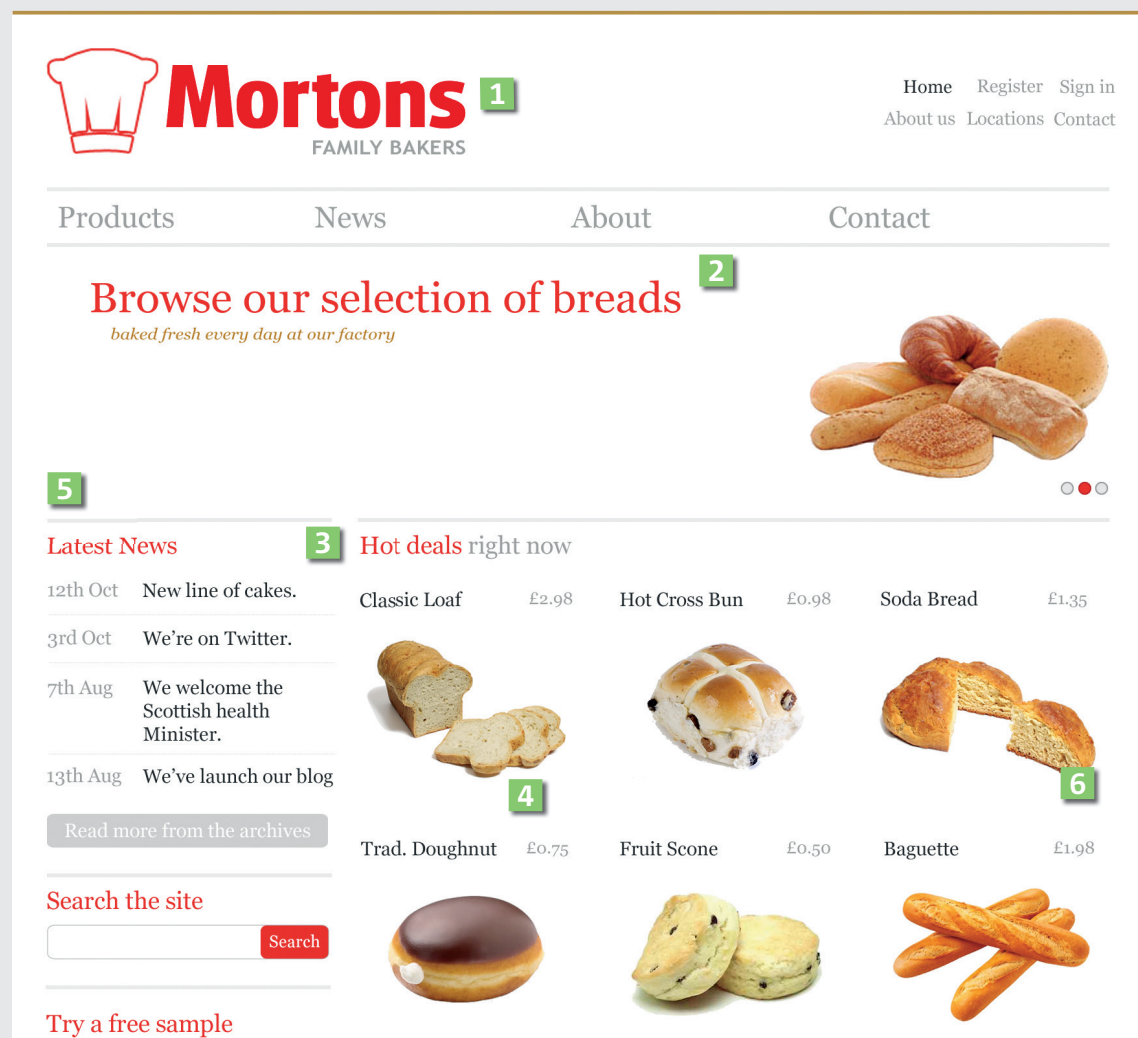
The key focus of the design is to get information across as quickly as possible, which is why the site has been split up into three main sections: heading/branding, related information to the left and the main content section to the right.

The heading section incorporates the main navigational elements as well as the main/first call to action, acting as a large aesthetic banner. The banner reveals some of the most popular items within the site, enabling users to see what's popular and purchase items that they previously wouldn't have considered.

The related information section acts like a widget-based feature, listing recent news clippings, a search function and a free sample section. Offering free samples will help build the trust of new visitors, encouraging them to delve deeper into the site. This type of user interaction can help recreate the feeling of trust and good service that existing customers who currently visit the shop experience.

The primary aim of the main content section is obviously to sustain the visitor's interest and attention. The site sets about this by displaying a range of great photography, which helps convey an appealing feeling of freshness. The items are also displayed on an infinite scroller, so that more items can be exposed with fewer clicks. ●

Close up



1 Header This has been made big and obvious to help establish the information hierarchy of the page. The sub navigation falls below the main navigation and above the gallery banners.

4 Product pictures Using high-res photography gives users the chance to see the quality of the produce. The photography is set as a background image, which means images aren't squashed into small areas.

2 Banner This acts as the first major call to action on the site, and enables visitors to view the most popular items within the online store, which are typically also the most clicked-on items.

5 Sidebar As the focus is on the products within the main area, all secondary items are placed within the sidebar. This will incorporate items such as the latest news section and the search feature.

3 Hot deals Reinforces the low price and other popular items that are available. Typically this could be seen as the follow-on from the banner above. The items within this section are popular items within the store.

6 Page layout The layout is simply structured so that the main focus is on the products. All other elements on the page are there to support or entice visitors into exploring the tasty goodies on offer.

Rob Edwards' solution

My site is themed around a fictitious, family-run pie shop in North Yorkshire. Smithfield's, known locally as Smithy's, is an establishment that's very proud of its history and cherished place within the community.

My objective was to bring members of their pie-loving customer base together online, and also to attract new devotees by designing the site as a social hub. To create an authentic look and feel, I incorporated visual paraphernalia from the real-life shop. This provides an engaging experience for users online, and also intrigues people, encouraging them to visit the actual shop.

All site content is easily accessible from the homepage through introductions and feeds – presented in a light-hearted, welcoming and unconventional way. I've incorporated JavaScript

to add playful functionality to the user interface and Cufón to vary the way that dynamic content is rendered.

I wanted to create a lively, feature-packed homepage, but was conscious of the content maintenance overhead and limited budget. With this in mind, the site makes effective use of free web technologies such as WordPress plug-ins, the Twitter API and a Flickr feed to regularly serve up fresh content.

The sprinkling of user-generated content and numerous calls to action on the homepage should encourage visitors to interact with the site. I've also incorporated several mechanisms for two-way communication between the business and its customers. This would give Smithy's a regular stream of feedback into consumer responses to their actions. ●

Expert info



Rob Edwards' month

What have I been doing?

I've been busy getting involved with the new iPad and Windows Phone 7 applications we're creating. We recently launched www.peoplescollection.wales.co.uk – a user-compiled collection of Welsh culture.

Sites I've visited

I'm addicted to FFFFOUND! – you always stumble across something amazing and unexpected there. I've also been chuckling at the awesome Tipp-Ex Hunter vs Bear interactive video viral.

What have I been watching?

I've filled the void left by the end of 24 with a boxset of *Kath & Kim*. I find Australian comedy amusing for some reason!

What have I been listening to?

I've got into Plan B's soul-tinged album and it's prompted me to download some old Motown. I'm also in grave danger of playing The XX's debut to death.

Have your say ...
Got a suggestion for a new site build-off? Let us know at netmag@futurenet.com

.net

Close up



1 Look and feel I've included various objects and textures that might be found in the real shop. Hand-painted typography and aged aesthetics are designed to convey a feeling of vintage Britishness.

4 Audience engagement The Twitter feed, the blog comments and the suggestion box jointly provide mechanisms for direct communication between Smithy's and their customer base.

2 Featured products This prime spot is devoted to images of the shop's pies, which click through to product pages and online ordering options. The carousel of banners is operated by a JavaScript-powered lever.

5 Calls to action (CTA) Opportunities to engage with the brand through ongoing competitions and events are highlighted here. CTAs click through to blog posts, which are a pragmatic way of putting new features live.

3 Dynamic content Product-related changes are kept up to date through special features such as the Pie Chart and Pie of the Month, which would be easily managed through the site CMS.

6 Social media This section acts as the shop's obligatory social hub, encouraging new users to join the fun, share content with like-minded pie fans and explore other areas of Smithfield's online presence.